

The Murty Classical Library of India has placed in our hands a 'box' of 10 gems of translation

English of excerpts from texts 'of the purest ray serene'. These come not from his Elegy's 'dark unfathomed caves' but from celebrated mines of undimming wealth. The excerpts are rare in their provenance, their translations are true in the fidelity of their English beings, and as a 'set' form a chain and yet in their distinct individualities glint in autonomous freedom.

Rohan Murty's magnificent enterprise could not have done better than ask Ranjit Hoskote, poet and scholar, critic and translator par excellence, to curate this collection. His 'foreword' is itself a cabochon in design and impact. Hoskote does well in saying the terrain of the selection is South Asia, for calling it India would have restricted its geographical home to less than its dimensions spread all over that large and variegated area. From the Therigatha's Pali to Mir Taqi Mir's ghazals and other poems in Urdu, we have here in the space of a little over 200 pages, the gamut of the highest literary endeavours in the empires of Asoka, the Guptas, the Chalukyas, Vijayanagara, the Mughals, coming right into the times of the British Raj. And all in the highest contemporary English of the Constitution of India and incidentally that of King Charles III.

Why Tamil and Gujarati, to mention two language groups, do not figure in the anthology is a question so predictable and trite that I will not pose it. That the book will soon be followed by a sequel covering uncovered ecologies of the written word is a hope so ardent that I will express it.

Hoskote uses the 'we' over 'I' in his 'foreword'—a sign of becoming modesty, and a way of including the galactic array of translators into his solo expression—a handsome thing to do for the translations included are of the standard of gold, measure for measure, carat by carat , revealing both the potential and the need for that exercise.

When proof-reading leaves the odd misspelling unattended, it only makes the product look human rather than the work of an unblinking machine. *Ten Indian Classics* has been put together by skilled humans with a touch so light as to make the 'classic' whisper rather than climb decibels. And in that soft appeal to the sensibility of the reader, reach its goal—the rapture of the experienced word. ■

–Gopalkrishna Gandhi

Alban (a constant presence in her writings), but also the couple's late-career, very public support of Manohar Parrikar–then the state's ascendant political force–which they eventually came to regret.

At Home... belongs in the long Goan tradition of memoirs as cultural history, alongside fine contributions as disparate as the Pali scholar Dharmanand Kosambi's solemn *Nivedan*, and pop star Remo's rollicking eponymous autobiography. In his deeply affectionate foreword, Vivek Couto says this "labour of love" was crafted by his mother as "an elegy for an older and more inclusive Goa, recognising its religious complexity and its role as the Panchayati Raj of Gandhiji's dream while confronting the modern Goa, its corruption, and the destruction of much that was good, or, arguably, great". Interestingly, he also notes the last paragraph of her last essay was judged "too depressing" so it was rewritten by Couto's grand-daughter, but we might surmise it supplied a final judgement about what she wrote in her brave and admirably forthright press note in 2015: "I am deeply saddened by the spiralling descent into communalism in Goa among my friends who have valiantly fought for secularism and liberal values all their lives. Intolerance which is vitiating the air nationally will do irreparable damage to Goa's legendary secular ethos."

COUTO was eulogised as the "grande dame of letters and culture of Goa" and even as "Goa personified"

At Home... is an indispensable primer, in which the then-octogenarian writes about her beloved homeland with terrific acuity and elegance: "Despite political instability for two decades or more after Liberation, and early attempts to force Goa's merger into Maharashtra (where it would have languished as a taluk or, at best, a district) the cultural strength of Goa lies in what politicians of all stripes describe as *Goenkarponn*, its uniqueness. This singularity is due to its history and, equally, to its landscape.... Both of these created a Goan identity, which, even now, resists all attempts at assimilation." ■

–Vivek Menezes